

Executive Summary

On January 20th, 2025, Donald Trump retook office. Since then, the Trump Administration has focused on reforming and undoing policies the Biden administration created. Trump signed numerous executive orders along with his **loyalist administration** to expand executive power. Trump's informal manner and political agenda has led to **unprecedented** decisions within his second administration.

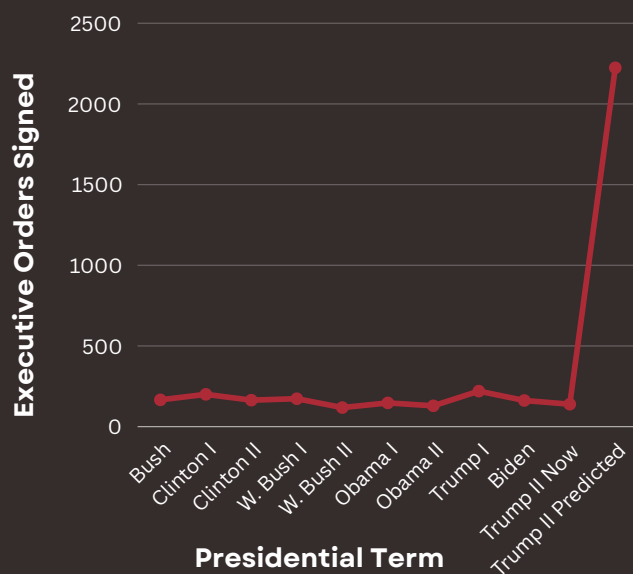
Background

- The purpose is to study the process that goes behind president Trump's policymaking
- Using this new insight on Trump's policymaking process, we can forecast the potential direction of Trump's future policies

The Use of Executive Orders

- Executive orders are "signed statements about how the president wants the federal government to be managed" (Boak, 2025)
- Executive orders do not need to be passed through Congress and can go into full effect as soon as it is signed or can take years depending on what agencies will need to make the changes
- Trump's use of executive orders has been the most convenient way to control the federal government
- The current executive orders have been based on **deregulation**
- 31 out of 139 of Trump's executive orders have had legal action taken against them
- Legal limitations of executive orders:
 - Cannot override existing law
 - Cannot withhold funding already approved by Congress
 - Cannot create government agencies
- Recently signed executive orders:
 - Having the U.S. exit the World Health Organization (WHO)
 - Rescinding 78 of Biden's executive actions
 - Reform the Federal Bureaucracy by ending government programs

Executive Orders Signed by Presidential Term



(The American Presidency Project, 2025)

As of April 29, 2025, Trump has signed 139 executive orders. During his first month, he had already signed 70, the most of any president in the last 40 years. Using his current pace, Trump is predicted to sign roughly 2,224 executive orders in total.

Key Highlights

- Trump prefers loyalists over "career civil servants"
- Trump's policy making decision's are influenced by his own ideals and his surrounding advisor's, who have a "black and white view of the world"
- Trump's Nationalist Populism (Bonikowski, 2019) agenda is about emphasizing the American Identity
- Trump's agenda is influencing the further political polarization between Democrats and Republicans.
 - **Polarization** - significant division between major groups based on views and beliefs
- Trump's "America First" agenda helps shape his policies including anti-immigration and foreign policy
- Trump does not explicitly follow *Project 2025*, but he often aligns with the roadmap laid out by the policy blueprint

Trump and Power

- Trump controls Congress, with a Republican majority in the House and Senate
- Due to Trump's control, his formal nominees for his administration have all been admitted
- Trump is signing more executive orders than creating laws through Congress to avoid a formal legislative process, a strategy with greater risk as orders are easier to reverse

Party Division

- Partisan polarization is a rising issue in the U.S government
- Representatives have been aligning with their party to keep their position of power
- Democrats and Republicans are **shifting away** from shared ideologies
- The 2025 election results were highly influenced from the 7 swing states since 43 other states are highly partisan towards one-party.
- The U.S. House of Representatives has become increasingly divided over the past years

Project 2025

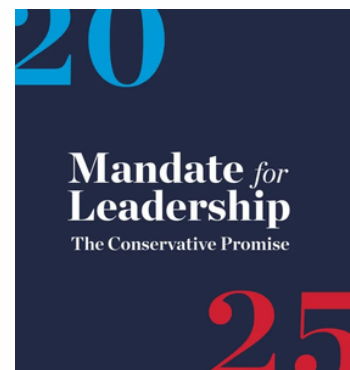
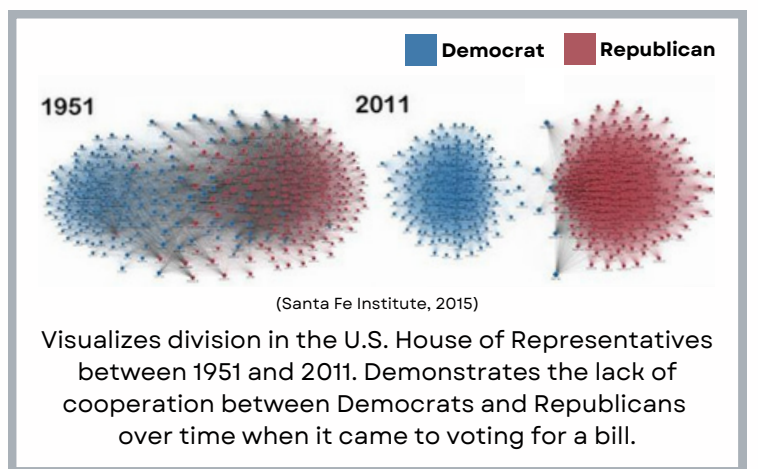
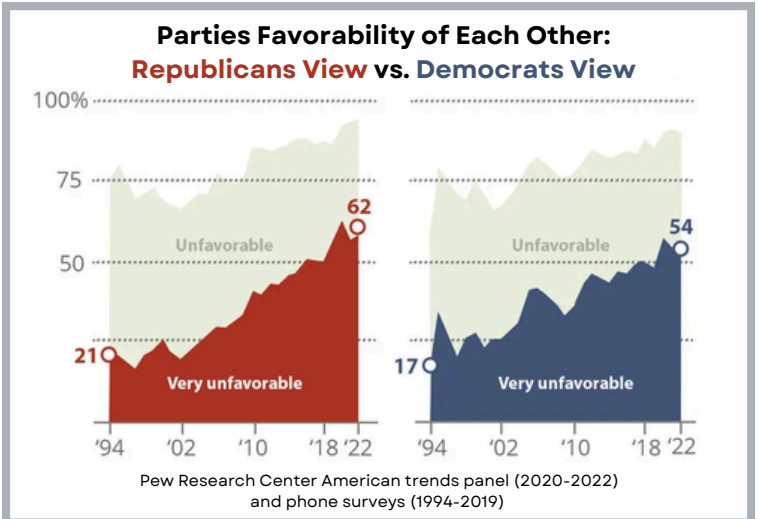
Project 2025 is closely aligned with conservative ideologies. Currently, 144 people in Trump's second administration played a role in crafting the policy blueprint, including representatives in high-ranking government positions such as the head of the Office of Management and Budget and current White House Chief of Staff.

Key ideas in *Project 2025* Trump aligns with:

- Aggressive Stances Against DEI Initiatives
- Immigration Control
- Border Enforcement
- Abolishing the Department of Education
- Appointing Loyalists Over Career Civil Servants
- Rolling Back Climate Policies
- Taking Efforts Against Renewable Energy
- Reducing Environmental Regulations
- Withdrawing From International Institutions

Conclusion

Donald Trump and his administration have a history of **unpredictable behavior** making it challenging to measure if the new implementation of policies will be successful. Trump's style of presidency is considered unconventional due to his decisions despite the concern and risks surrounding them. Due to his political agenda, the Trump administration has made misguided political decisions. Trump chose his administration due to their ideals aligning with his political agenda and their loyalty to him. Trump caters to the American audience by presenting his policies in an informal manner through a **nationalist populist style**. Donald Trump's style has been successful in maintaining engagement and creating a passionate political base that supports his administration initiatives.



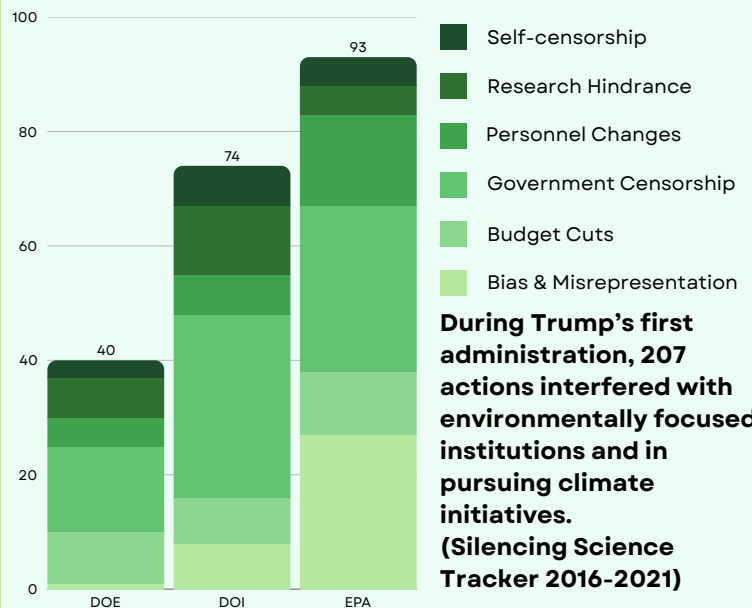
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Trump's second term has resulted in federal denial of climate change and **derailing** of stronger environmental regulation. This brief examines the rationale behind these decisions. Highlighted, are actions such as the removal of climate change related data, deregulatory actions within the EPA, and policies following *Project 2025*. These actions are actively **dismantling** U.S. environmental standards, reshaping policy direction for years to come.

Background

- The purpose is to assess Trump's administration's environmental policy and reasoning behind them
- By understanding Trump's environmental focus, we can forecast how environmental policy within the U.S. will look in the future

Federal Institutional Interference Actions by Agency



Removal of Climate Change Related Information

More than 2,000 datasets disappeared from Data.gov during the Trump administration, likely due to shifts in policy priorities (Disappearing Data, 2025). This reduction in public data has sparked discussion about the government's role in ensuring access to information.

EPA's Largest Deregulatory Action in U.S. History

31 environmental regulations were rolled back from previous administrations, mainly from the Obama and Biden administration. These rollbacks aimed to strengthen American fossil fuel and automotive industries, with the goal of increasing job growth to strengthen the economy.

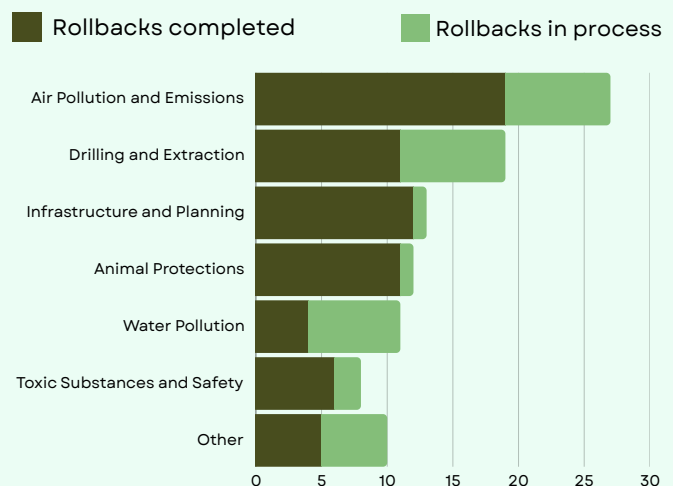
Following *Project 2025* Policy Blueprint to Determine Policy

The withdrawal from the Paris Agreement, efforts to cut EPA staff, dismantle NOAA, and open protected Alaskan lands for drilling shows a clear push to weaken agencies that regulate the environment. These moves match the Project 2025 blueprint, hinting at what future environmental policy might look like.

Outcomes of Deregulations

- Leaving the Paris Agreement removes long-term nationwide environmental goal
- Decreased funding in climate change impact research, but has not diminished the climate efforts states have made.
- Removal of ~4,800 federal employees from environmental related agencies including the EPA, DOI, and DOE, weakening agencies ability to fulfill their missions.
- Increased usage of fossil fuels, including coal, oil, and gas
- Reduction of efforts being made towards renewable energy such as solar and wind

Trump Administration Reversed 100 Environmental Rules



As of July 2020, the Trump Administration has focused on rolling back climate initiatives, which experts forecast to intensify in Trump's 2nd administration. (Buchholz, 2020)

Trump 2017-2020	Biden 2021-2024	Trump's 2025-Present
2021-01-13 EPA Issues Rule to Hamstring GHG Regulations This regulation added restrictions to future greenhouse gas rules affecting acts like the Clean Air Act.	2021-01-27 White House Launches Government-wide Climate Action This order established the expansion of governmental bodies to address climate change and agencies to prioritize environmental justice.	2025-01-20 Executive Order 14154 - Unleashing American Energy The order prioritizes fossil fuel development and removes regulations in place that hinder its development.
2021-01-05 EPA Finalizes Rule to Limit Use of Scientific Information Limits use of scientific studies when data is not becoming publicized. Leading researchers to lose study participants due to privacy reasons.	2021-02-24 Biden Orders Review of Renewable Energy, EV Supply Chains This order directed a review of battery and mineral supply chains to support clean energy and strengthen U.S. manufacturing.	2025-01-21 Executive Order 14173 - Ending Illegal Discrimination and Restoring Merit-Based Opportunity The order is to end DEI and DEIA policies and rescind Executive Order 12898, which addresses environmental justice in 1994.
2020-10-29 Trump Administration Lifts Protections on Country's Largest National Forest Protections on the Tongass National Forest were lifted, allowing for roads to become built after the established Roadless Rule in 2001.	2024-03-07 SEC Finalizes Climate Change Disclosure Rule The SEC finalized a rule requiring public companies to be more transparent about how they manage climate related financial risks, helping investors make more informed decisions.	2025-03-07 Department of Defense cancels Social Science Research, Including Climate Change Impact Studies The announcement is a response to Trump's Executive Order, Restoring American's Fighting Force, which prohibits the DOD from "promoting, advancing ... un-American, divisive, discriminatory, radical, extremist, and irrational theories."

Conclusion

Trump and his administration have reconstructed, eradicated, and changed environmental policy, claiming climate change is setting America back, preventing the economy from flourishing. Trump has rolled back climate initiatives and defunded environmental agencies to push the fossil fuel industry forward. Deregulation has been a standard protocol, yet there is **uncertainty** in the direct path the administration plans to pursue. However, the current environmental actions align with the *Project 2025* blueprint. Under the Trump Administration environmental policy is **regressing** while climate change is evolving. For the Trump Administration, extraction of non-renewable resources through drilling, promoting the fossil fuel industry, deregulating common environmental standards, and withdrawing from the Paris Agreement are some of many efforts being done to bolster the U.S. economy. While these actions reflect Trump's first term, his prior experience has made his current efforts more effective in advancing his agenda.



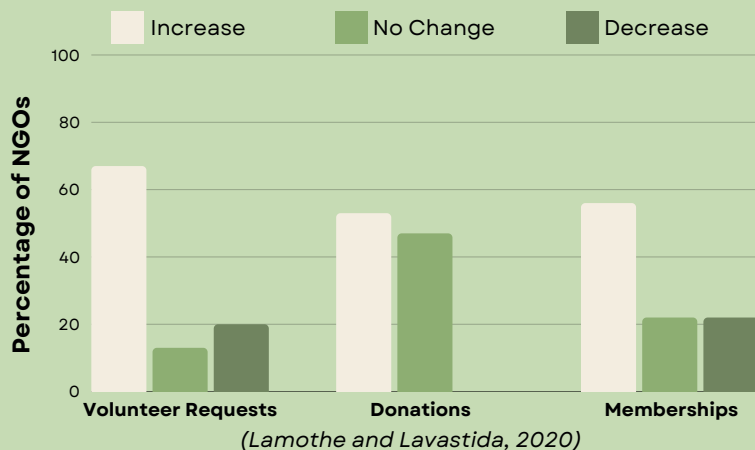
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The Trump administration has focused on reversing initiatives supported by NGOs, especially those against his **“America First” agenda**. Since Trump’s first day in office, he has signed numerous executive orders that **weaken** NGOs by cutting government funding they rely on. NGOs have been forced to take action to protect their funding while fighting harder to advance the issues they support, such as, environmental protections, public health, and humanitarian aid. Key actions include expanding fossil fuel production, rolling back renewable energy efforts, and **defunding** programs aligned with NGO-led initiatives.

Background

- The purpose is to understand how Trump is affecting NGO’s ability to achieve their goals
- Explore the strategies being used by NGOs to combat Trump’s executive authority

Percentage of NGOs Change in Public Support



When Trump first took office, there was an overall increase in public support for NGOs. Poor public perception of Trump in his first term led to increased communal advocacy.

Professional Takeaways

“Regardless of what is happening, we have the ability at the state level to enforce environmental laws” (Connecticut State Rep. Kate Farrar, 2025)

“We’re getting further and further away from the goals we set in place, it’s logistically becoming a **nightmare** to advance advocating for these policies” (Sierra Club Vermont Chapter, Program Manager, Robb Kidd, 2025)

“He basically said he is going to use the power of the Executive State to **block** state environmental policy” (Sierra Club Vermont Chapter, Program Manager, Robb Kidd, 2025)

What are NGOs?

Non-governmental Organizations (NGOs) are independent, non-profit groups that work on public environmental, legal, and community issues for the general public. NGOs have the influence to fight back against federal rollbacks and intrusive policies through the use of:

- Legal Action
- Policy Advocacy
- Collaboration with other organizations
- Generating public support

Federal Defunding of Programs

Sierra Club (Vermont):



- Solar for All
- Bike and Pedestrian Infrastructure
- Landscape Conservation Cooperation

Sierra Club (Wyoming):



- Clean Energy Transition
- Public Lands Conservation
- Extension of Coal Plant Retirement Plans
- Home Energy Efficiency Freeze

League of Conservation Voters:



- Transportation and Emissions Standard Rollback
- Heat Pump Incentive
- Offshore Wind Development

Inflation Reduction Act

The Inflation Reduction Act (IRA) was implemented in 2022 by the Biden administration. The act aimed to recover the economy by investing in climate change initiatives like clean energy, tax reform, and healthcare. Trump signed Executive Order 14154 to suspend funding from the IRA, effectively rolling back another policy from the Biden administration. This action heavily affects NGO’s funding for programs relating to renewable energy.

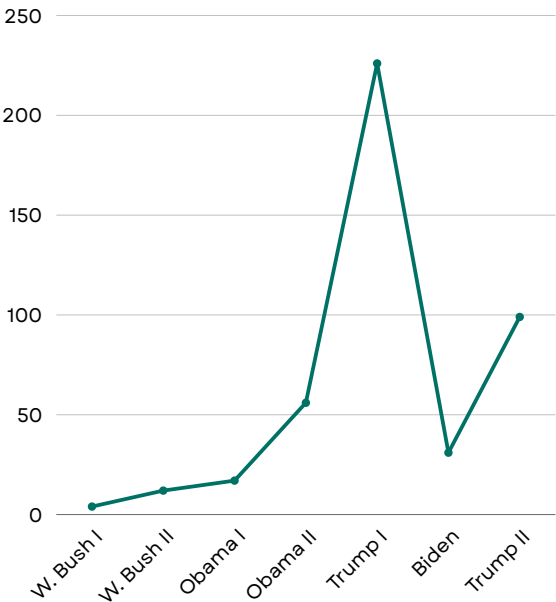
NGOs V.S. Executive Order (EO)	Earthjustice, Natural Resource Defense Council, Sierra Club v.s. EO 14154 Unleashing American Energy	Earthjustice, Center For Biological Diversity, National Resource Defense Council, Greenpeace, The Sierra Club v.s. EO 14153 Unleashing Alaska's Extraordinary Resource Potential	Earthjustice, Natural Resource Defense Council, Sierra Club v.s. EO 14156 Declaring a National Energy Emergency
Details	Aims to expand oil and gas leasing in federal waters and fast-track energy	Lifts restrictions on protected areas in Alaska to promote drilling and mining	Grants agencies emergency power to fast-track fossil fuel projects by bypassing key environmental regulations
Claim	• Harms ecosystem • Disregards public right to participate in leasing decisions • Violation of environmental review laws	• Weakens protections for ecologically sensitive lands in Alaska • Accelerates environmental projects without proper assessment or consultation, violating a number of environmental laws	• Considered unjustified and violates environmental laws • Allows federal agencies to avoid environmental reviews

“We're [Sierra Club] involved with a lawsuit against DOGE, for legally laying off federal public lands workers and legal budget cuts. That's the other side of the strategy that we use; grassroots engagement and then litigation at the federal and state level”
(Jones, 2025)

Conclusion

Under the Trump administration, NGOs have found themselves on the **defense**. Through waves of executive orders and reversing policies, the administration has aimed to **defund** many NGO supported initiatives. NGOs now find their focus divided between continuing their advocacy work and fighting to secure the funding necessary for launching new initiatives. Critical funding that supports renewable energy, land conservation, and improved public transportation has been **frozen**. As a result many NGOs have shifted to filing lawsuits against the federal government. These executive actions have directly threatened key environmental, humanitarian, and community priorities, making it difficult for them to attain their goals.

Legal Battles Fought By NGOs



(Clearinghouse, 2025)

As of April 29, 2025, there have been 99 litigations at the federal level initiated by NGOs. Trump holds the previous record for the most legal battles with 226, but it is likely this amount will be surpassed by his second administration.

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A number of industries have expressed public **concern** in response to President Trump's recent executive orders and his enforcement of tariffs on foreign goods. These measures, which are affecting imports from all over the world, have triggered significant **disruption** across the retail, automotive, technology, and manufacturing sectors. While some companies have spoken out about price hikes, production shifts, and supply chain uncertainty, others have remained **cautious** or silent, weary of political repercussions.

Background

- The purpose is to inform how the Trump administration is causing uncertainty, affecting industries nationwide
- Investigate how industries and CEOs are responding to these uncertainties

Uncertainty in Trump's Policy

Trump has demonstrated a policymaking approach marked by **sudden** changes, which has disrupted how industries operate, particularly in terms of long-term investments.

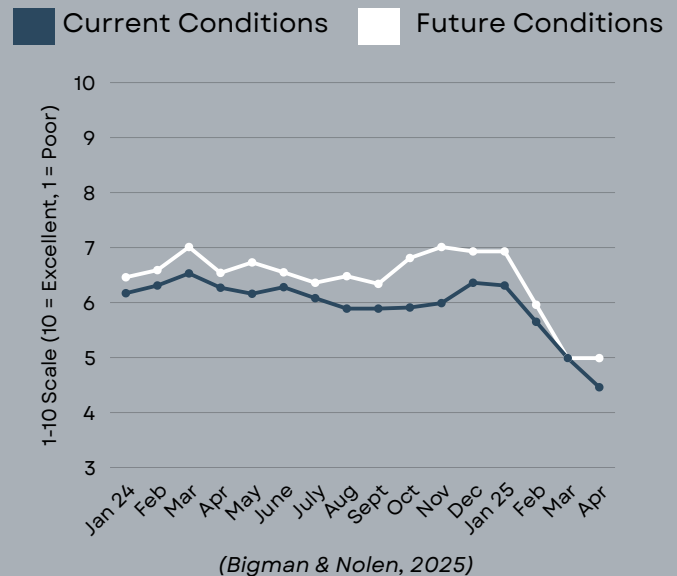
- Tariff uncertainty causes supply chain issues and makes it difficult to plan ahead
- Industries are delaying investments
- Companies are cutting back on hiring
- Some companies are changing operations from previous commitments

Below is a graph demonstrating economic and policy uncertainty within the U.S. News Based Index represents shifts in public or media uncertainty. Three Point Index represents a more complete measure of uncertainty, using news, tax codes, and expert economic opinion.

Companies Avoiding Criticism

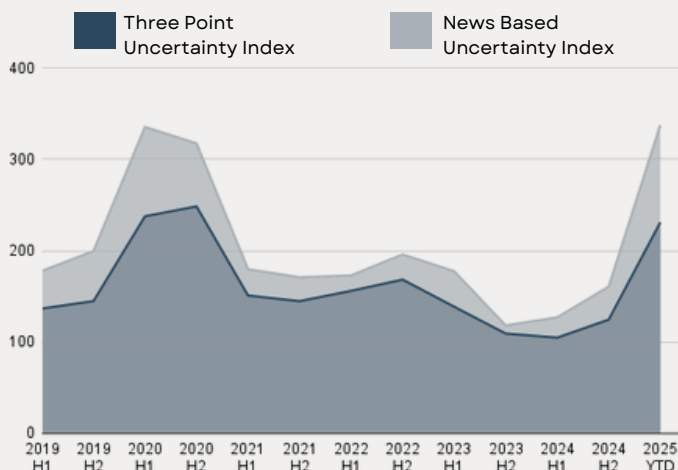
Many major companies appear to be hiding their true opinion to stop any potential **retaliation** from the government. This silence may be a result of something unique to Trump; open retaliation via social media. A study conducted between 2016-2018 found that tweets from Trump with very negative opinions on companies resulted in statistically significant drops in stock prices (Brans and Scholtens, 2020).

CEO Confidence Index



CEOs are increasingly losing their confidence for future conditions amid tariffs imposed by the Trump administration. A total of 67% of businesses report not supporting Trump's policies, while 76% believe the policies will hurt their business. This level of uncertainty and disruption hasn't been seen since the COVID-19 pandemic.

Three Point and News Based Economic and Policy Uncertainty Index



(Policyuncertainty.com, 2025)

Over the final year of Biden's presidency, the index remained stable, yet, in just a few months of Trump's presidency, the index has spiked.



Goldman Sachs

“The prospect of a recession has increased, with growing indications that economic activity is slowing down around the world.”
-David Solomon, CEO

ExxonMobil

“The polarization and political back-and-forth that we see in [the U.S.] is not good for the country, not good for society. It’s frankly not good for business”
-Darren Woods, CEO,
11 November 2024

“Change is important. It was needed. The issue always is: How fast, how much? ... The president needed to shock people, which he has done, and make changes, because without a shock, changes don’t take place.”
-Farooq Kathwari, CEO

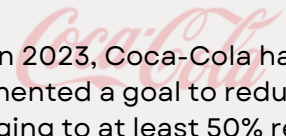


“Everyone is afraid.”
-Dan Pickering, CIO



“Prices will be higher 10 years from now, and 20 years from now, and 30 years from now”
- Warren Buffet, Chairman and CEO, 2025

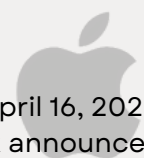
Environmental Actions Taken by Major Industries



In 2023, Coca-Cola had implemented a goal to reduce their packaging to at least 50% recycled material by 2030. This goal changed due to the shifts made by the Trump administration. CEO James Quincey said “if aluminum cans become more expensive, we can put more emphasis on PET bottles” (Quincey, 2025).



In 2016, Walmart introduced a plan to reduce their emissions by 2030. Recently, Walmart became concerned, stating they are likely to miss their target due to factors “outside of their control”. These factors include public policy, transitions in energy systems, and cost effectiveness of low carbon technologies (Walmart, 2025).



On April 16, 2025, Tim Cook announced that Apple surpassed their 60% reduction in greenhouse gas emissions. This is a milestone in the overall goal of reaching 0% carbon emissions by 2030 (Apple, 2025).

Conclusion

The implementation of the Trump administration’s new policies has produced a significant impact on major corporations, raising concerns among CEOs and business leaders. Specifically, the introduction of tariffs on a large scale has affected company performance due to rising costs. The current economic climate has contributed to a decline in business confidence and led to executives voicing their **concerns** about trade, tariffs, and challenges surrounding imported goods. Leaders who were once optimistic have come forward to express their disapproval of Trump’s new actions. However, there are still many CEOs who have opted to remain quiet due to potential backlash. The **uncertainty** caused by Trump’s **rapid** policy implementation can be felt throughout American industries, creating instability and hesitancy to invest in long-term goals.